Chapter One

The Menace of the Aurora Borealis

‘I suspect that few planets survive their nuclear age.’[1]

(Stanley Kubrick)

‘I swear I believe Armageddon is near.’[2]

(President Ronald Reagan)

‘This means war with the Soviet Union.’ [3]

(Robert McNamara)

The Cuban missile crisis is one of most intensively and imaginatively studied events of the twentieth history, befitting what many believe was the moment when humankind faced its moment of maximum peril. There is a huge amount of literature on the subject. Historians (and other scholars) have learned how decisions were debated and what actions were taken. Yet, there are many things we do not know and some that we continue to learn about. There are other things we are unlikely to know. There are some we can never know.

Indeed, there remain questions of transcendent importance that are inevitably matters of speculation and debate. How close did we come to Armageddon (and beyond)? Would political leaders have ‘pressed the button’? If so how, when, and why? How would military officers have acted if they thought it their duty to use weapons of mass destruction whether or not they had orders to do so? Some answers have changed as new evidence and fresh interpretations emerged. Yet, at the heart of the quest for understanding is not simply what happened, how and why, but speculation